

ACCREDITED CLUB PROGRAMME
PART OF ENGLAND FOOTBALL

BETTER EVERYWHERE

Thriving Community Clubs Conference 2026



WELCOME MESSAGE

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Welcome to your 2026 FA Thriving Community Clubs Conference, an event dedicated to supporting, connecting and developing grassroots clubs to be better everywhere.

This conference is about making sure you have everything you need to become the best you can be. To help you get there, we've lined up a series of practical workshops, collaborative sessions, and networking opportunities. We encourage you to share what's working for you and learn from each other, so you'll leave with useful actions for your own community.

This workbook is here to help you do this. Use it in whatever way suits you - scribble notes, sketch ideas, mark which sessions you've been to, and answer the prompts as honestly as you can. It's designed for you to take away and make positive changes, using the tools and frameworks you already have.

We hope you enjoy every session and leave full of ideas and plans for this season and beyond. Thank you for coming, and for the brilliant work you do in making football more enjoyable and better for everyone.



Name:.....

County FA:.....

Here's a few starter questions to get you thinking:

Knowing my patch

Number of 3-Star Accredited Clubs: .....

Number of 2-Star Accredited Clubs: .....

Number of completed Club Development Reviews:.....

Number of Club Development Reviews Outstanding: .....

Which pillars provide the greatest opportunity and progression for clubs? .....

Which pillars are the biggest barriers for clubs? .....

Teamwork & collaboration

Who are my FA Club Consultants? .....

Do we need to recruit additional FA Club Consultants? .....

Who do I need to get closer to in my County FA, in the network and across stakeholders? .....

Development mindset

What are my strengths? .....

Where can I improve? .....

Who can I engage with to improve my knowledge or fill any gaps? .....

BREAKOUT WORKSHOPS

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As part of pre-registration, we've got two workshops for you to choose from:

1. The National League System
2. Data and Digital

Use this space to write down which workshop you attended, alongside any notes, key learnings and take aways.

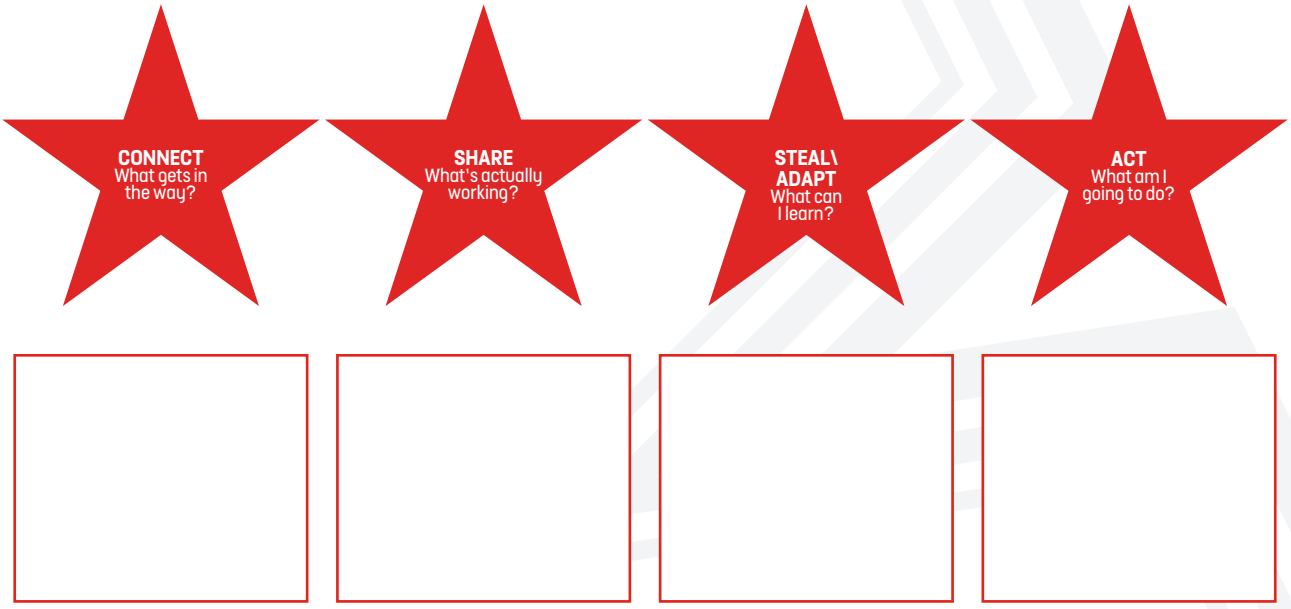
TEAMWORK & COLLABORATION

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This session will aim to show you what great collaboration looks like, using other people's real examples of what works.

You should walk away with at least one thing you can steal or adapt to your own club, as well as a solid group of people to stay connected to.

Use this framework to capture the key points:



County FAs have told us these four things are their biggest challenges:

1. Club engagement and volunteer capacity - 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | 6 | 7 | 8 | 9 | 1 0

2. FA Club Consultants - 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | 6 | 7 | 8 | 9 | 1 0

3. County FA staff capacity and collaboration - 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | 6 | 7 | 8 | 9 | 1 0

4. Resources, budget and interventions - 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | 6 | 7 | 8 | 9 | 1 0

On a scale of 1 - 10, (1 being the lowest, and 10 the highest) where do you feel you currently are for each of these challenges?

Which are more of a problem than others?

.....

Which are you doing quite well at?

.....

In 6-12 months time, we encourage you to revisit these scores. How have the conversations, connections and actions you've taken from today helped to improve them? Jot them down below to keep a record.

.....

.....

PILLAR NETWORKING

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In this session, you'll use your own CDR/RAG data to size up your club on your allocated pillar. It'll give you insights into your pillar, a clear understanding of any underlying problems, and solutions you can use right away.

Circle which Pillar Networking you attended.



Leadership & Governance



Coaches



Volunteers



Facilities



Community

Note, you'll visit the pillar(s) where your 3-star and 2-star club development reviews were flagged as either red or amber. This is not a general discussion, but specific to the places you're responsible for turning into Thriving Community Clubs.

What's driving that rating? Remember, this is not the symptom, it's the root cause.

What the root causes are

What are the barriers that are blocking progress?

Make a list of tactics and interventions the whole network could use to cure these root causes. These will feed into the Pyramid of Progression session this afternoon..

Now consider the other pillars and headlines areas. Where might the root causes exist, and what the problems could they cause?

ACCELERATING PROGRESSION

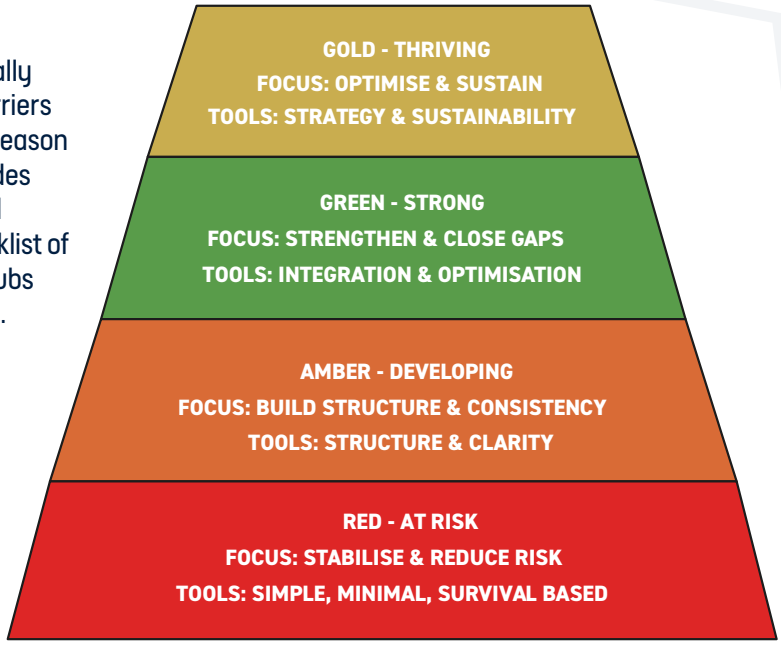
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This session will turn learnings from the earlier Pillar Networking session into a real two season plan for your Thriving Community Clubs. You should leave today with a clear plan and timeline for your launch and an intervention checklist.

Our goal is to have 500 more Thriving Community Clubs from pipeline clubs by 2028, with female/disability provision embedded and sustained.

It's important to know where your clubs actually sit. Now you've found the root causes and barriers blocking progress, you're going to plot a two season deployment and intervention plan. This includes tools, retention tactics, governance ideas and collaboration practices. We will create a checklist of activity and support services to help 3-star clubs thrive and 2-star clubs get better everywhere. The activity will involve sequencing a two season plan from this morning's sharing and networking sessions.

What comes first, what comes second, and when is FACC 1:1 deployed? Use this space to flag anything that's more about developing the people, versus what's accelerating Progression:



2026/27 Season

Quarter 1	Quarter 2	Quarter 3	Quarter 4

2027/28 Season

Quarter 1	Quarter 2	Quarter 3	Quarter 4

EMPOWERING THE CLUB WORKFORCE

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This session is about understanding the volunteer development framework, and finding actionable interventions to help you become a Thriving Community Club.

By the end of the session, you'll have created a County FA plan and Club Based plans for the headline areas of the volunteer pillar.

Here's some key ideas to think about:

What are the tactics and methods that are working to support volunteer growth and capacity in thriving clubs?

How will you match off-pitch development pathway opportunities to the right individuals and leaders within clubs?

What are the biggest opportunities we have or are missing?

How do we empower clubs to improve skills based leadership and transition from predominantly volunteers to having paid roles within clubs?

Who are the agencies and organisations you could explore locally to diversify the club workforce, find skilled volunteers and transition to a mix of paid and volunteer staff?

LEAD – MANAGE - DO

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Use this section for any notes you have from Sue Day's 'Leading the Orchestra' key note speech.

To move our Lead-Manage-Do understanding forward, we'll be asking you about what you're actually putting into practice. These peer-to-peer conversations using real examples will give you the chance to share challenges across the network.

Use this space to make notes around the activity framework:

1. WHAT NEEDS TO HAPPEN? Start with a real club/priority/challenge. Instead of asking, 'what am I going to do?', try 'what actually needs to change here?'

2. WHO HAVE I GOT AROUND ME? Think about the expertise and relationships already around you, within your CFA, FA support, Club Consultants, partners and the wider network. Who is actually best equipped to help make this happen?

3. WHAT IS MY ROLE? Make a conscious choice:



There is one big challenge sitting underneath it all. Ask yourself the question, 'What am I currently doing that somebody else might be better equipped to do?'

GROWING PAINS

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We want to make sure you're ready for the growth pressures that come with Thriving Community Clubs, with real, tangible examples.

You'll leave this session with more awareness of the pressures you might face as you grow quickly, and exactly what you need to be prepared for.

Note down common pressures and ways you can mitigate against them.

What are the common threads?

What are the key identifiers that will help you recognise what pressures are on a clubs horizon?

What are the biggest opportunities or what do we have missing to be equipped to support and service clubs that grow fast?

What are our biggest opportunities, and what are we currently missing when it comes to supporting fast-growing clubs?

DEMONSTRATING IMPACT

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The objective of this session is to agree on expectations and how we demonstrate real impact through Club Development Reviews. By the end, you will have a clear understanding of what these reviews look like and what to expect for both your club and county.

List the clubs below you have supported in specific pillar areas, which is not yet shown in their CDR:

List the clubs you envisage will tell the best story and demonstrate the greatest impact by the end of the 2026/27 season:

List the clubs you feel will be the best-in-class case studies over this 4-year strategic cycle (2024–2028). These will be clubs that tell the whole story, demonstrate getting better everywhere against the 5 pillars, and are truly thriving community clubs:

What will be your approach to reviews to ensure your RAGG data is accurate and to tell the stories of clubs?

MY BETTER EVERYWHERE GAMEPLAN

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This page is for you to capture your reflections throughout the conference. What were your key learnings? What do you want to take away? Have you identified any definite actions and follow ups?

The following questions may help you get started:



MY COMMITMENT

Now write a final pledge for yourself. Identify what it is and then commit to it so your learnings from this conference go far beyond these two days.

I will.....

Signed : ..... **Date:** .....

NOTES

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